

Why Are We Always Waiting to Start Living?

There is a quote often attributed to the Dalai Lama that describes a strange contradiction in human life:

We sacrifice our health to make money. Then we sacrifice our money trying to recover our health. We worry so much about the future that we forget to enjoy the present. And eventually, life passes us by.

Whether or not the Dalai Lama actually said these words, the idea behind them is worth thinking about.

Because how often do we tell ourselves:

“I’ll enjoy life when I have more money.”

“I’ll relax when I finish this project.”

“I’ll travel when I can afford it.”

“I’ll spend more time with my family when work becomes less demanding.”

“I’ll start doing what I really want when I have more time.”

There is always a “when.”

And sometimes that “when” never arrives.

Why Are We So Focused on the Future?

Planning for the future is not a bad thing.

We need to think about tomorrow. We need to save money, build careers, take care of our health and prepare for unexpected problems.

The problem begins when preparing for the future consumes the present.

We can become so focused on creating a better life later that we don't notice that we are already living our life now.

A person might spend twenty years working toward financial security, only to discover that they have missed many of the experiences they were working so hard to afford.

This is one of the strange contradictions of modern life.

We are constantly told to invest in our future.

But what happens when the future becomes the only place where we allow ourselves to be happy?

The Cost of Always Saying “Later”

Think about the things you have postponed.

Maybe there is somewhere you want to travel.

Maybe there is a hobby you want to pursue.

Maybe there are people you want to spend more time with.

Maybe there is something you have always wanted to learn.

Maybe you simply want to slow down.

Why haven't you done it?

Sometimes the answer is completely reasonable.

You genuinely don't have the time or money.

But sometimes the answer is:

“Later.”

Later is one of the easiest words to use when we are afraid to make a change.

And the danger is that later can become a habit.

We keep postponing the things that make life meaningful because we are waiting for the perfect circumstances.

But life rarely gives us perfect circumstances.

Are You Living or Just Preparing to Live?

This is the question I find most interesting.

Are we actually living our lives or are we constantly preparing to live them?

We go to school so we can get a good job.

We get a job so we can earn money.

We earn money so we can afford a house.

We buy a house so we can feel secure.

We work more so we can afford more things.

And then we become too busy working to enjoy them.

There is nothing wrong with ambition.

There is nothing wrong with wanting financial security.

There is nothing wrong with building a career.

But these things are supposed to support our lives, not replace them.

The Present Is Not an Obstacle

Sometimes we treat the present as if it is simply a waiting room for the future.

We are waiting for the weekend.

Waiting for vacation.

Waiting for retirement.

Waiting for the right relationship.

Waiting for more money.

Waiting until we become healthier, wealthier, more successful or more confident.

But the present isn't an obstacle standing between us and the life we want.

The present is the only part of life we actually experience.

The future matters.

But the future is always becoming the present.

That means if we spend our entire lives waiting for tomorrow, tomorrow eventually becomes today and we may simply continue waiting.

What Does a Balanced Life Look Like?

I don't think the answer is to stop thinking about the future.

That would be another extreme.

A healthy life probably requires both.

Prepare for tomorrow.

But don't sacrifice every experience today in the name of tomorrow.

Save money.

But allow yourself to enjoy some of what you earn.

Work hard.

But remember why you are working.

Take care of your health.

But don't become so obsessed with optimizing your body that you forget to actually enjoy being alive.

Plan your future.

But don't make the future responsible for your happiness.

Try Asking Yourself These Questions

If you feel like you are constantly working, worrying and waiting for life to begin, it may be worth stopping for a moment.

Ask yourself:

What am I constantly postponing?

What am I working so hard for?

If my financial situation improved tomorrow, what would I actually do differently?

Who would I spend more time with?

What experiences do I want to have?

What makes me feel genuinely alive?

And perhaps the most uncomfortable question:

If nothing about my current lifestyle changed for the next ten years, would I be happy with where it takes me?

You don't necessarily need to change your entire life after answering these questions.

Sometimes one small change is enough to begin.

Call someone you haven't spoken to in a long time.

Go somewhere you've always wanted to visit.

Start the hobby you've been postponing.

Spend an evening without your phone.

Take a walk without having somewhere to be.

Have a real conversation.

Do something simply because you enjoy it.

Don't Wait for Permission to Live

There will always be another bill.

Another responsibility.

Another goal.

Another problem to solve.

If we wait until everything is finally under control before we allow ourselves to enjoy life, we may spend our entire lives waiting.

The future deserves our preparation.

But the present deserves our attention.

Maybe the goal isn't to choose between planning for tomorrow and enjoying today.

Maybe the goal is to build a future that doesn't require us to sacrifice the present.

Because eventually, all of us will reach the end of our lives.

The question is not whether we will get there.

The question is what we will have done along the way.